

Good thing Shiv Shankar Prasad Chowrasia said his mind was "blocked" after he won India's first-ever European Tour golf event, the Emaar-MGF Indian Masters. Good thing he only read the newspapers at home, taking a pre-paid taxi from Kolkata airport the morning after being handed over the single biggest pay cheque—\$4,16,660 (Rs 1.6 crore)—given to an athlete in India. Good thing there were familiar faces on the fringes grinning reassuringly at him all along.

Because for 'SSP', everything else was designed to make his head spin. Inside a couple of hours on the Delhi Golf Club (DGC) course, he went from being a face on the fringes himself to a golfer with a three-year invite on the European tour. Inside a day, they were saying he had a smile to match Tiger's and a short game in the same league of Ballesteros. It was insane, extreme, but Chowrasia's life has often been familiar with both.

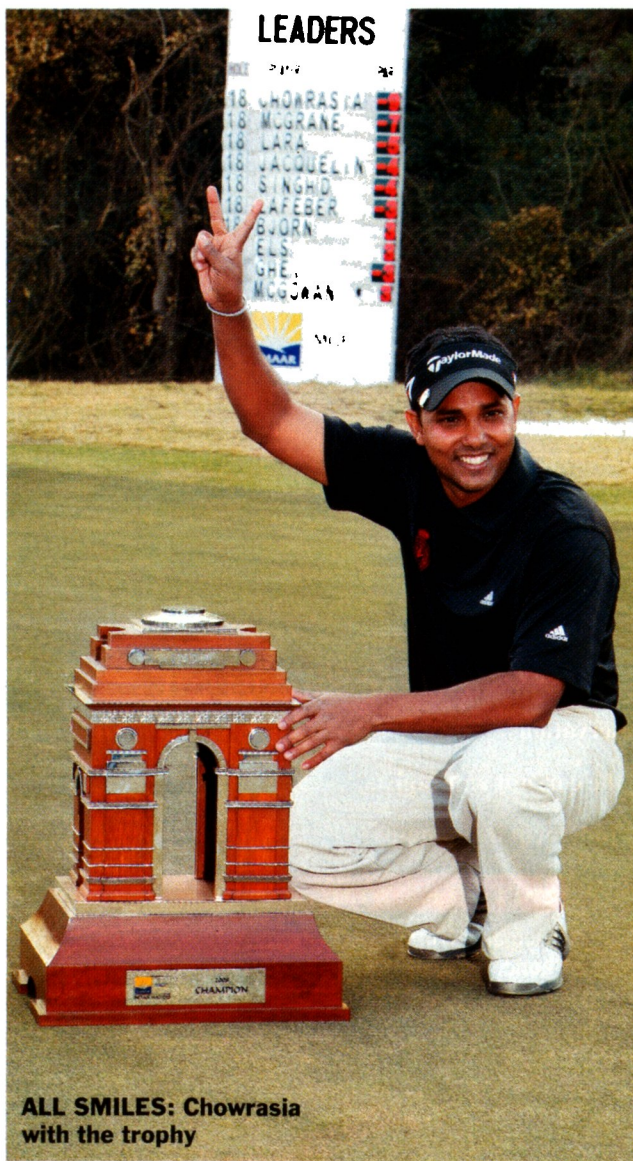
One of the four sons of a Royal Calcutta Golf Course (RCGC) green keeper, Chowrasia dropped out of school in Class VI to teach himself golf and earn a living as a caddy. His oldest brother still drives a lawnmower at the club and two others take turns at caddying for their youngest, the one who can fly. Self-coached and nudged along by his home club, Chowrasia, 29, played the final day of the Masters in a black T-shirt with the red RCGC crest on it.

A 10-time winner in the Indian tour, Chowrasia has travelled on the Asian tour for two years, with five top 10 finishes, including a runners-up spot, earning just under \$2,40,000 (Rs 95 lakh) before his dream weekend in Delhi.

In these two years, his mindset has shifted, his world grown but his sense of wonder has remained intact. Once nervous about leaving home for his first pro event in Patna,

INDIA MASTER

SSP Chowrasia stops fancied rivals cold as the European Tour golf arrives in India



ALL SMILES: Chowrasia with the trophy

today he flies between countries, takes to physical training and is game to try sushi. Now Europe with its links courses and filthy weather beckons, and Chowrasia has been even talked about the US. Many worry about his chances in such completely alien worlds, but worriers and dreamers rarely pick the same road maps.

An Indian champion in the country's first European Tour event was more than just a result, it was a statement. That the home contenders were strong enough to stare down European pros including Majors winners and Ryder Cup champions.

Chowrasia's victory was celebrated through the rank and file of his sport. Among the scorers on the DGC course were Nonita Lall Qureishi and Vandana Agarwal, flag-bearers for women's golf. Walking in the crowd on the final afternoon was Rohtas Singh, India's first widely-known caddy-pro who, in 1974, played his first pro tournament in slippers. On the sidelines was Ali Sher, a spiritual predecessor of sorts, the first Indian pro to win an international event.

There were others. Like the DGC layabout who heard noise on the 11th green and began to run. "*Birdie maara*," he said urgently, "*Chowrasia birdie maara*." Like the workers, who had installed coffee machines for the hospitality areas, listening to Chowrasia's victory speech.

He thanked a long list including sponsors and organisers and the workers marvelled at his ease, surrounded by suits and speaking in Hindi. One laughed, "*Kaise bol raha hai... arre yaar, Chowrasia ho gaya hai big sot*." (Just listen to him, Chowrasia's become a big shot.") His companion replied, "*Big ho ya small, sot toh hamaara hai*." (Big or small, he's our shot.)

by Sharda Ugra

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